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# Public Speaking

## Lecture 17: Digression- Uses and Concerns

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**“Attention is the  
currency of  
persuasion.”**

**- Aristotle**

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# What is Digression?

- ❑ Merriam Webster defines Digression “as the act or an instance of leaving the main subject in an extended written or verbal expression of thought : the act or an instance of digressing in a discourse or other usually organized literary work”.
- ❑ Digressions are instances when the speaker moves away from the decided topic. This usually happens only for a short period of time.
- ❑ It is different from distraction.



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## Attention vs Digression

# ATTENTION

The prime component of any successful act of public speaking is the speaker's **skill to capture and hold the audience throughout the speech delivery.**

However, one can never keep the audience engaged with facts alone. In order to grab their attention, the **speaker must include relevant digressions** during communication.

So, digression is a way of grabbing attention and refreshing the audience and should be incorporated during speech delivery.

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# Distraction is not Digression

Distraction, during any speech delivery, is not digression but nuisance that one must avoid at all costs. Some of the distractions are:

- ☐ Use of slang
- ☐ Use of jargons
- ☐ Fidgeting and fiddling
- ☐ Continuous repetition
- ☐ Excessive use of speaker notes

## Continued...

- ☐ Pacing the floor (the caged tiger syndrome)
- ☐ Use of complicated language
- ☐ Excessive use of visual aids
- ☐ Use of passive sentences
- ☐ Use of weasel word
- ☐ Wearing inappropriate clothing

# Why is Digression Inevitable?

- ❑ Any public speech is live and spontaneous.
- ❑ It cannot be edited like any piece of writing.
- ❑ The speaker aims at keeping the audience's attention intact.
- ❑ The speaker usually digresses and gives a personal anecdote in order to reinforce a point.



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# Importance of Digression

- ❑ Digressions are employed by the speaker to create a surprise effect.
- ❑ They are not part of the overall course of the speech.
- ❑ They help the speaker to develop a relationship with the audience.
- ❑ A speaker uses digressions to introduce additional information.
- ❑ Digressions are capable of fetching new layers to the speech.





## Continued...

- ☐ Digressions make the speech more captivating.
- ☐ Lower pitch is usually employed to deliver.
- ☐ The speech might turn out to be more colloquial because the speaker is digressing.

Digression is the soul of wit. Take the philosophic asides away from Dante, Milton or Hamlet's father's ghost and what stays is dry bones.

-Ray Bradbury



# Kinds of Digression

Digressions that  
are simple fillers

Little digressions  
that makes sense  
only at the end

Digressions that  
make the public  
laugh but without  
changing the main  
message

# Digressions and Associated Concerns

Digressions can be extremely distracting if not checked. One can get easily get carried away while speaking and lose track of the original idea. While giving personal touch, one should always keep in mind that it is all for the audience.



# Keeping Digressions in Check

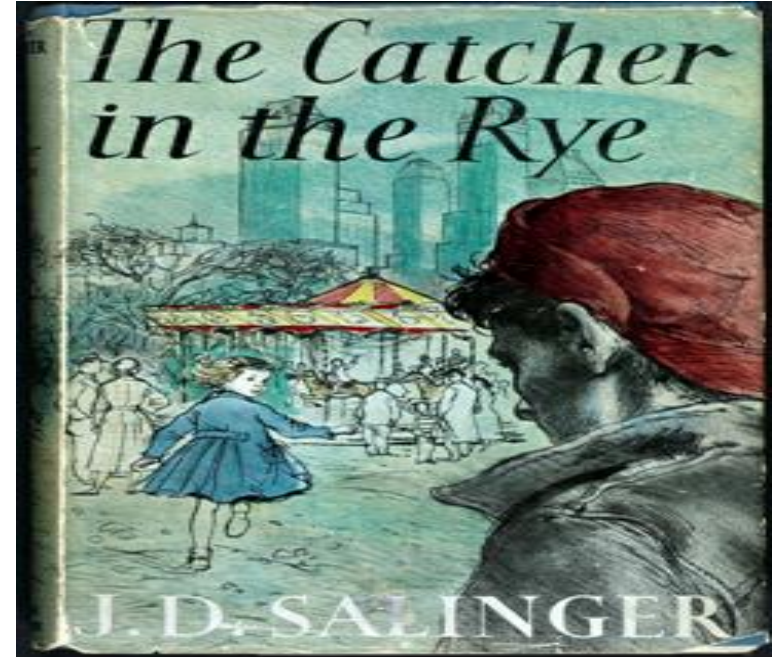
- ☐ Analysis of speech is very essential.
- ☐ One should make sure that the original thought is intact in the delivery.
- ☐ One should try to analyse the purpose of the digression.
- ☐ Digression must be short-lived.
- ☐ Use of Voice Modulation is essential in order to depict hierarchy of the ideas.



# Literary Example of Digression

J. D. Salinger's novel *The Catcher in the Rye* is rich with digression.

There are numerous instances when Holden Caulfield's thought patterns seem to derail from the main topic. However, these digressions later fit the missing pieces for gaining insight into the protagonist.



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## Do Audiences also digress?

- ❖ Audiences have the qualities of a crowd
- ❖ Their minds wander constantly
- ❖ Audiences move faster than the speaker's
- ❖ They have spare capacity and they often daydream



# Gaining Attention

- ✓ Arouse questing interest
- ✓ Vary the input
- ✓ Utilize the speed and volume of voice
- ✓ Provide breaks and alterations
- ✓ As speaker, be sensitive to the audience's mood



Variety  
Length of time  
Time of day  
Arousal  
Motivation

# Arousal tactics

- ❖ Share audiences' needs and interests
- ❖ Ensure their security
- ❖ Empathize with your audience
- ❖ Ensure enthusiasm





“Nothing is more to the point  
than a good digression.”  
— Ralph Caplan

Thank You



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